



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRICAIN DES ETUDIANTS
UNIÃO DOS ESTUDANTES DE TODA A ÁFRICA
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GENDER ADVOCACY
WORKING GROUP

GENDER POLICY

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Forward

Over the past decade, the All-Africa Students Union has been keen on ensuring an inclusive education in Africa. The Union achieves inclusivity through one of its seven strategic priorities; Gender Advocacy and its rigorous compliance to its goal oriented Gender-Policy. Categorically, we have implemented several gender-focused projects including the Africa Girls Back to School Campaign, Education Enrolment Program, World Youth Skills Day, and Tech-Girl Empowered which have contributed immensely towards holding global gains in terms of eradicating gender inequality. The impact of these projects have been realized across Africa. Through our Africa Girls Back to School Project that engaged 29 African countries with well over two hundred volunteers from across these countries, a significant number of girls have overcome barriers to quality education post COVID -19.

Beyond promoting access to quality education which forms a part of our core mandates, the Union has made considerable efforts to advocate for gender equality across different sectors of the African economy. It is noteworthy that the numerous feats attained by the organization have thrived on the back of the Union's holistic gender policy document that have ensured that AASU stays committed to integrating gender perspectives in the overall strategic planning and programming of the organization.

According to the Global Gender Gap Report which measures the progress of gender parity across the parameters of Economic Participation and Opportunity, Educational Attainment, Health and Survival, and Political Empowerment, it will take another 132 years to close the global gender gap. The gender gap has been reduced globally by 68.1% in 2022 as compared to the 2021 forecast. However, it does not make up for the generational loss that occurred between 2020 and 2021. In this vein, it is expedient that organizations take pragmatic steps in contributing their quotas towards global efforts to close the existing gender gap.

AASU's Gender Policy expresses its commitment in taking proactive steps to further gender equality both at the program and institutional level. This policy document is a result of comprehensive research and consultation with employees, partners, youth and students as well as insights acquired through the implementation of past AASU Gender policies. It articulates AASU's role in promoting the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development as a partner with governments and other partners, and is based on the human rights principles of non-discrimination and equality.

In order to make gender equality a reality for the entire organization, I rely on your full cooperation in implementing the Gender Equality Policy and Strategic Plan in your respective activities.

Thank you.

Forwarded by

Peter Kwasi Kodjie
Secretary General





Introduction

AASU is the largest student movement in Africa and a very dominant force on the Continent and beyond. The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) is the umbrella organization for all African students from the basic level to higher learning institutions and a very dominant force on the African Continent and beyond. With over 71 Member Unions across the Continent, AASU represents over 170 million students in Africa and the diaspora. Since its inception in 1972, AASU now has a presence in 54 Countries in Africa. AASU's vision is to be a leading organization in mobilizing, coordinating and involving African students in all the efforts geared towards the socio-economic, political and cultural advancement of Africa. AASU's key strength lies in its diversity and numerical strength; which it employs as a bargaining tool to speak for the supreme interests of students at all times. The Union is made up of diverse students, regardless of their religion, gender, cultural background, or social standing.

AASU's vision is to be a leading organization in mobilizing, coordinating and involving African students in all the efforts geared towards the socio-economic, political and cultural advancement of Africa.

AASU's mission is to create, amongst the broad masses of Africa, awareness of the problems, confronting the continent and the need for students, as an integral part of their society, to be fully involved in the endeavors aimed at resolving them.

Rationale

This policy outlines AASU's commitment to gender equality and the principles enshrined in International Human Rights agreements such as the Convention on the Elimination of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW), the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, UNICEF amongst others. For AASU, Gender equality implies that the needs, interest and priorities of both women and men are taken into consideration; Gender equality is not only women's issue but should concern and fully engage both men and women. Equality between women and men is seen both as a human rights issue and as a precondition for sustainable people-centred development.

The overall goal of this policy is to set the standard and principles of gender equality under which AASU operates and create systems, programmes, processes and practices for mainstreaming Gender Equality towards AASU's vision free from all forms of exploitation and discrimination.

The rationale of this policy is to help AASU achieve its goal of leveraging the power of students' leadership to alleviate in Africa all forms of inequality through advocacy, education and its wide range of well selected programs. Gender equality, we believe, is a necessary condition for a better and safer world. This policy outlines our commitment to integrating gender equality into our programs and organization in a consistent, meaningful, and purposeful manner.

Objectives

The policy's objectives include;

- Facilitate and Support the integration of gender perspectives in overall strategic planning and programming of the organization.
- Clearly define the principles of Gender Equality and take appropriate measures to adopt a shared vision to guide staff, executives, member unions and partners in their work with a clear direction to promote Gender Equality and equity at organizational and programmatic level;
- Develop an organizational culture that demonstrates AASU's commitments towards gender equality and students empowerment.
- Promote girls' and women's equal participation in learning and decision-making.
- Create a gender-sensitive and inclusive organizational culture within AASU.



Scope

The policy, which primarily serves as internal guidance, lays forth a shared vision, strategic priorities, and procedures for incorporating gender views across the Organisation. The Executive body of the All-Africa Students Union are in charge of enforcing this policy, which is applicable to all staff of AASU. The policy provides broad strategic orientations for implementation, including expanding gender equality across all areas of the organisation's mandate and institutionalizing gender equality in the organizational culture of AASU.

Guiding Principles

A

The empowerment of women and girls is recognized as fundamental to AASU's vision and mission and forms a part of AASU's seven strategic priority areas namely, Gender Advocacy, Education & Students Rights, Pan-Africanism & African Culture, Democracy & Good Governance, Capacity Building, Migration & Mobility, and Environment & Climate Action. AASU believes that all persons are born with equal dignity and rights, thus everyone is entitled to all of the rights and freedoms outlined in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, regardless of race, color, sex, language, religion, political or other opinion, national or social origin, property, birth or other status, sexual orientation, or gender identity. AASU's initiatives are designed to help everyone reach their greatest potential.

B

Focus on girls and women

In most contexts, looking at gender equality requires a focus on girls and women because of historical, systemic and structural inequalities. Although men and boys also face discrimination, our emphasis is on addressing inequalities affecting women and girls because they are more often targets of discrimination and gender based violence. Our major focus is on protection and participation of young women and girls in our seven strategic priority areas,

C

Justice, diversity and inclusion

We strive to create diverse workplace and programs that eliminate inequity, discrimination, and prejudice. We recognize that other dimensions of identification, such as race, religion, ethnicity, nationality, ability, sexual orientation, and others, can reinforce uneven access and opportunity. At all levels of the union, we address barriers and offer opportunities for women and men to participate equally.

D

Zero tolerance to sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment.

AASU recognizes its obligation to take action if it suspects or observes sexual exploitation, abuse, or harassment in its programs, member unions or workplaces. Sexual exploitation, abuse, or harassment by any of AASU's member unions, employees, partners, associates, funding partners, interns, or volunteers is not tolerated (team members). Exchange of money, commodities, or services for sexual favors from team members and beneficiaries is strictly prohibited. We encourage and have processes in place to handle sexual misconduct as soon as possible.

E

Every individual understands clearly and demonstrates attitudes and behaviours that promote gender equity and equality.

**F**

Adequate resources are allocated to work on promotion of gender equality and women's Empowerment.

G

All work is continuously monitored against gender indicators based on different country Contexts.

Commitments

1

Mainstreaming Gender Equality:

Gender equality is integral to its seven strategic priorities, that is Education and Students' Rights, Capacity Building, Pan-Africanism and African Culture, Environment and Climate Action, Demography and Good Governance, Migration and Mobility and Gender Advocacy which plays a key role in facilitating the integration of gender perspectives in the overall strategic planning and programming of the organization.

- The Secretary for Gender and International Relations assesses at the continental and national level, the implications for women and men of any planned action, including policies, legislations or programs in all areas.
- The Secretary General ensures that gender equality commitments are conveyed to sponsors, donors and development partners (marketing, communications and fundraising strategies) to drive donation activity.
- Technical Staff and specifically heads of the various strategic areas are responsible for mainstreaming gender equality into strategic initiatives that are led by their teams.
- AASU liaises with its member unions to ensure that a gender analysis is conducted at least once in the four-year cycle in each of the 54 countries we have presence in. Programs, projects and strategic plans are informed by the results of the analyses.
- Gender Officers prepare background papers, publications and publications on time relevant gender issues and ongoing projects.
- Make sure that females take an active role in humanitarian efforts at all times and in all programs and projects including during readiness, response, recovery, and rehabilitations.

2

Strengthening our capacity

AASU trains its staff in gender equality and gives them the knowledge, tools and ability to integrate the principles of gender equality in all its work.

- Promote gender equality by inducting new employees and providing them with training
- Hone key competencies in gender equity, gender awareness, and core values both equality
- Ensure that all staff training is gender-sensitive throughout the organization on the subject of gender equity and gender-responsive behavior.
- Make all HR systems and procedures gender-sensitive and adding gender indicators to staff goals in performance management systems.



3

Promoting Gender Aware, Safe and Inclusive Workplaces:

Due to AASU's presence in 54 African countries, it is committed to having diverse and inclusive workplaces where every individual has opportunities and access to available resources to reach their full potential. AASU pursues family-friendly work policies and practices that enable everyone to participate fully in work and family life;

- The Secretary General of AASU adopts a strategic initiative on globally equitable family-friendly workplace measures like maternity leave and flexible work arrangements;
- AASU's Work Culture ensures we have a zero-tolerance policy on preferential or discriminatory behavior as well as towards Sexual Exploitation Abuse and Harassment; and
- AASU ensures that recruitment, development and advancement policies are inclusive of underrepresented groups.

4

Advocacy, Networking, Partnership

- Encourage engagement of women and girls while recognizing gender diversity and interconnectedness numerous local, national, and international forums, committees, and meetings.
- Network with like-minded people at the national and international levels to forge alliances and collaborations organizations that support women's empowerment and gender equality
- Influence national policies for justice, equality, and empowerment of women for putting policy into action through defending women and students rights at many levels.
- Help partners increase their ability to conduct gender analysis at the policy level and institutional levels, as well as to create and implement programming that supports female parity.

5

Ensuring Equal Representation:

We strive for a 50% representation of females in our working groups at all levels and in country coordination and mobilizations. We take active steps to recruit and train more females into leadership and other positions where they are under-represented.

- The Executive body targets a fair representation representation of females on the Executive Board.
- All Program Officers establish female representation goals for their teams.
- Gender Officers collect and analyze gender parity data annually.
- Gender Officers together the Secretary for International Relations report annually to the Secretary General on gender parity in the organization; and
- The Human Resource Unit ensure that their hiring and retention practices move their office towards greater parity.



6

Monitoring, Evaluation and Learning (MEL): AASU measures Gender Equality for evidence-based decision-making and continuous improvement.

- The Secretary for Gender and International Relations ensures that Gender Equality indicators from continental indicators are included in proposals.
- Monitoring and Evaluation Officers are responsible for integrating gender equality into baseline, monitoring and evaluation; and
- Monitoring and Evaluation Officers are responsible for ensuring equal representation and participation of girls and women (as beneficiaries and enumerators) throughout the measurement and evaluation cycle.

7

Resources and Financing

To achieve gender mainstreaming throughout the organization, it is imperative to have adequate financial and resource arrangements. There will be enough resources allocated to all projects and programs to put the gender policy into practice across the organization and its member unions.

8

Accountability and review

- Each Staff of AASU, is accountable for successfully implementing the Gender Policy. Each working group under its lead will be responsible in taking appropriate steps for ensuring gender mainstreaming to promote gender equality.
- Every staff of AASU entities should make all necessary efforts to study and become fully acquainted with the Gender Policy and its implementation.
- This policy also requires to document or disclose reasons for not having diversity in any item mentioned in this document with the intention to review the reasons towards ensuring progressive increase in inclusion.
- The policy will be available to all staff both in English, French, Portuguese and Arabic.
- The Secretary for Gender and International Relations is ultimately responsible for the implementation of the Gender Equality Policy. The Secretary of Gender and International Relations report annually to the Board of Executives and congress on progress towards implementation of the Gender Equality Policy.



ANNEXES

ANNEX I-Glossary:

Gender: Gender refers to socially constructed roles played by women, men and other gender identities that are assigned on the basis of sex. Gender is used as a means to distinguish similarities and differences between women, men and other sexual identity people without direct reference to human biology, but rather to the behavioural patterns expected of women and men and their cultural reinforcement. These roles are usually specific to a particular area and time.

Gender as crosscutting: Cross-cutting issues are topics that affect all aspects of a program.

Gender Equity: Gender equity means the fairness of treatment for women, men and other sexual identities, according to their respective economic, social, cultural needs. This may include equal treatment or treatment that is different but which is considered equivalent in terms of rights, benefits, obligations and opportunities. In order to ensure fairness, measures must be taken to compensate historical and social disadvantages and create a level playing field for both men women and other sexual identities. It is a means to achieve the ultimate goal of Gender Equality

Gender Equality: Gender equality entails the concept that all human beings, both men, women and other gender identities, are free to develop their personal abilities and make choices without the limitations set by stereotypes, rigid gender roles, or prejudices. Gender equality means that the different behaviours, aspirations and needs of women men and other gender identities are considered, valued and favoured equally. It does not mean that women men and other gender identity have to become the same, but that their rights, responsibilities and opportunities will not depend on whether they are born male or female. Gender

Equality is the ultimate goal in sustainable development.

Gender Mainstreaming: Gender mainstreaming has been embraced internationally as a strategy towards realising gender equality. This involves making gender perspectives – what women and men do and the resources and decision-making processes they have access to more central to all policy development, research, advocacy, development, implementation and monitoring of norms and standards, and planning, implementation and monitoring of projects.

Both dimensions – gender representation and gender responsive content - need to be taken into consideration in all phases of project/proposal/institutional development.

Gender Analysis: Gender analysis is a systematic way of looking at the different impacts of development, policies, programmes and legislation on women men and other sexual identity that entails, first and foremost, collecting sex-disaggregated data and gender-sensitive information about the population concerned.

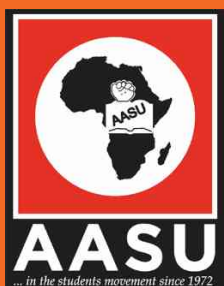
Gender-Responsive Work Environment- Gender-responsive work environments are made by addressing the needs of women and reflecting an understanding of the realities of women's life. A gender-responsive workplace acknowledges a number of significant distinctions in daily living.



ANNEX II-REFERENCES:

CEDAW and the Human Rights Based Approach to Programming: a UNIFEM guide (2007)
OHCHR Gender Mainstreaming Strategy (2002)
Global Gender Gap Report(2022).





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